The Civil War

By Robert James

Section 1

Wilmer Mclean

Wilmer Mclean

- A successful grocer and sugar distributor to both the North and the South.
- His brick home in Manassas VA was the site of first major land battle of war, the first battle of Bull Run in July 1861.

Wilmer Mclean

- Home was commandeered by Confederate General Pierre Gustave Beauregard to serve as his headquarters during the battle, and was later damaged by Union shelling and still later it was taken over by Union General Irwin McDowell, as his Headquarters.
- What of Wilmer Mclean? Eager to escape the ravages of war, he abandoned his home in Manassas and moved his family and over 100 miles south to Appomattox Courthouse, VA and built a new brick home.
- More on Wilmer Mclean later.

Section 2

How the War was fought

How the War was fought

- In Napoleon’s time, infantry attacked on a narrow front in tight-packed columns with bayonets fixed, a king size spear point, if you will.
- The columns smashed into the enemy line like battering rams.
- Such sledge-hammer attacks had succeeded largely because the standard infantry weapon used by all armies was the short-range, single-shot, slow-to-load smoothbore musket, all of which had to be loaded the same laborious way:

How the War was fought

- A paper cartridge containing a powder charge and a lead ball was torn open with the teeth;
- Powder and ball were dropped into the gun's muzzle, followed by the paper, which served as wadding, and the whole load was driven down the length of the barrel with a ramrod.
- To fire the weapon a soldier ignited the powder charge by an unreliable flintlock mechanism: A chip of flint on the weapon's hammer created a spark in shallow pan primed with a little powder from the paper cartridge. The weapon would not fire when the powder was wet, or even damp. When the weapon did fire, which was about 80% of the time, the ball was unstable in flight and accurate only at short ranges of up to 200 yards.

How the War was fought

- Because the musket was a short-range weapon, the Napoleonic infantrymen and cavalrymen could safely advance close to the enemy line; upon advancing their charge, they would only briefly suffer losses to the defensive musket volleys before they began their grisly work with bayonet and saber.
- By 1861, smoothbore muskets were still used, but were more reliable in that they used the new percussion caps, cuplike copper casings containing a small amount of an explosive such as fulminate of mercury, which made the muskets virtually certain to fire, even in foul weather. Another improvement had turned the smoothbore musket into a rifle, as the interior of the barrel was now scored with spiral grooves. This rifling gave the bullet, now a pointed lead missile, a stabilizing spin when it was fired, the result of which was a dramatic increase in the accuracy and range of the weapon. In the hands of a good marksman, a rifle could now hit an enemy soldier 600 yards away.

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****Infantry Formation demonstration****

Glory – 1989 James Island Battle Scene

Section 3

THE WEAPONS USED BEGINNG IN 1861

The Weapons used beginning in 1861

- **At the outset of the war the armament and standing armies of the two sides were about as different as night as night and day. The industrial north had been manufacturing weapons for decades, weapons that were cutting edge technology of the times, whereas the south had little, if any weapons manufacturing in existence.**
- **The southern armament consisted basically of family held firearms like Kentucky Flintlock Muskets, squirrel guns, and shotguns; whereas the north had armouries stocked with Springfield Rifled Muskets, Colt Revolvers, several and calibers of field pieces (cannons), and mortars.**

Weapon types: Rifled Muskets

- Springfields and Enfields (imported From England) in both .58 and .69 calibers. These were used primarily by infantry and foot soldiers

Springfield rifled musket

Enfield rifled musket

Weapon types: The Revolvers

- .36 caliber and .44 Caliber Colt Revolvers and .44 Caliber Remington Revolvers.

.36 caliber Colt

.44 caliber Colt Navy

.44 caliber Remington

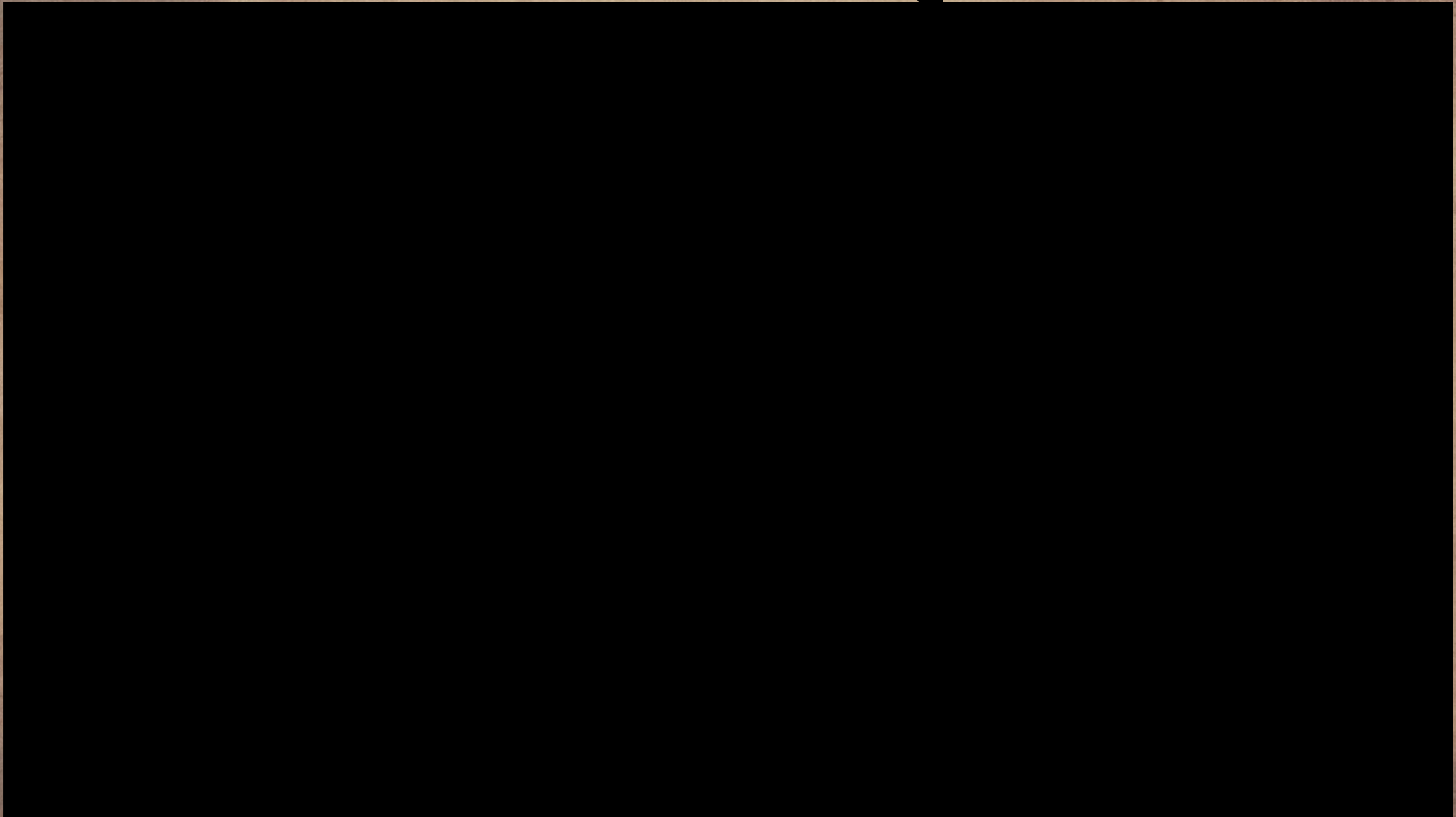
- Revolvers were primarily used by officers and Mounted Cavalry Troopers.

Weapon types: The Revolvers

- One notable exception in the south was the LeMat Revolver that the south obtained in limited quantities from France. This fearsome revolver held nine rounds of .44 caliber round lead balls and also had a central barrel thru the center of the cylinder which held a single shotgun charge. Although plagued with functional issues, it was still a formidable weapon.

.44 Caliber LeMat Revolver

Demonstration video – Loading Colt .44



Weapon types: Swords and Sabers

- Swords and Sabers were used by both sides, primarily by both mounted and Infantry officers.

1860 Cavalry Saber

1850 Infantry Officer Sword

Saber and revolver carry demonstration

Weapon types: Field Artillery (Cannon)

- **At the outset of the War, artillery differed little from that of Napoleon's time.**
- **The French Emperor had revolutionized the use of artillery by employing light, mobile field pieces that could dash to any threatened spot on a battlefield.**
- **The U.S. Army was quick to copy and improve on the French usage with its own mobile artillery – lightweight bronze cannon that were mounted on rugged carriages with big wheels.**
- **By the 1840's, the U.S. Army had the world's hardest-riding and swiftest-firing field artillery forces, and during the Civil War, gunners on both sides were proficient in the techniques of rapid deployment.**

Weapon types: Field Artillery (Cannon)

- The fieldpieces most widely used early in the War were muzzle-loading smoothbore cannon.
- They were notably inaccurate at long range, whether firing solid shot – iron balls weighing 6 – 12 pounds – or explosive shells.
- At closer range, in support of infantry, the cannon were far more effective.

Weapon types: Field Artillery Smoothbore Cannon

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- They were especially deadly at ranges of around 800 yards, using any of several types of loads.

Smoothbore Cannon

Field Artillery Load Types: Case Shot

- **Hollow balls packed with powder and clusters of small iron or lead balls – cut a great swath when they exploded amid an enemy formation.**

Field Artillery Load Types: Cannister Shot

- **Which resembled tin cans filled with oversized bullets, were even more lethal, hitting lines of soldiers with the effect of giant shot gun blasts.**

Field Artillery Load Types: Chain Shot

- Two solid cannon balls linked by a length of chain.

Field Artillery Load Types: Grape Shot

- Small rocks, broken glass, small pieces of iron, or anything that could inflict damage.
- This would be used as a last resort.

Weapon types: Field Artillery (Cannon) Rifled Cannon

- Could throw projectiles long distances with much improved accuracy.
- The Model 1861 Ordnance Rifle, which had a three-inch bore, could fire shot or shell nearly 4,000 yards, though its optimum range was around 2,400 yards.

Weapon types: Field Artillery (Cannon) Rifled Cannon

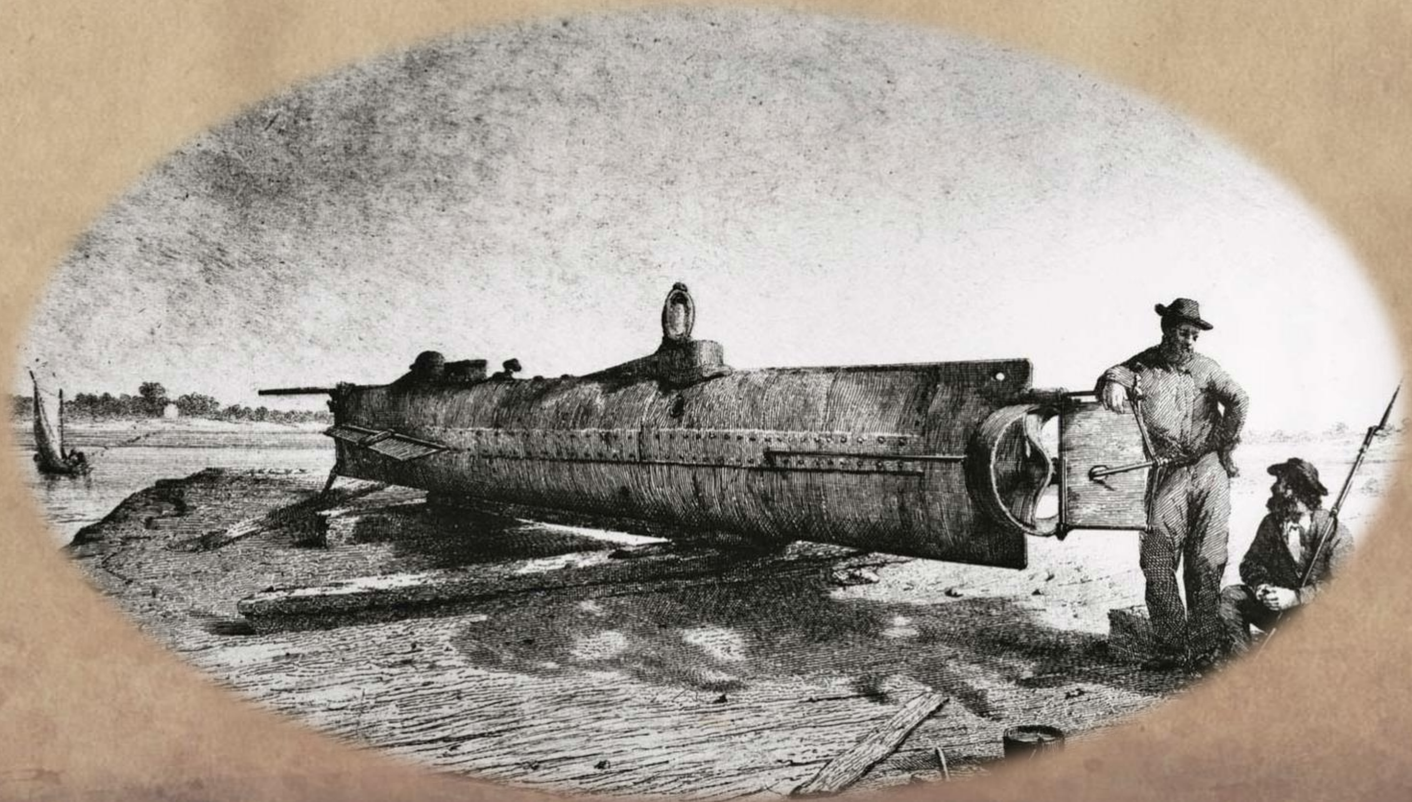
- The Parrott rifle, named for inventor Robert P. Parrott, came in various sizes from a 10-pounder, firing a projectile weighing 10 pounds, to a mammoth 30-pounder siege gun.

Rifled Cannon

Rifled Cannon

Section 4

The CSS H. L. Hunley



The CSS H. L. Hunley

- **With the capture of New Orleans in April 1862 and the subsequent seizure and control of the Mississippi River, the South was left with only its seacoast ports.**
- **It became apparent that whichever side controlled the coast line also controlled the shipping imports from Europe and Coastal America, which contained critical resources such as clothes, food, artillery, medicine and, at times, reinforcements.**
- **The Hunley was created to destroy the Union blockade and help gain this all-important advantage.**

The CSS H. L. Hunley

- Legend held that the Hunley was made from a cast-off steam boiler.
- In fact, Hunley was designed and built for her role. Each end was equipped with ballast tanks that could be flooded by valves or pumped dry by hand pumps.
- Extra ballast was added using iron weights bolted to the underside of the hull. If the submarine needed additional buoyancy to rise in an emergency, the iron weight could be removed by unscrewing the heads of the bolts from inside the vessel.

The CSS H. L. Hunley

- The hull of the ship is estimated to originally have been 4 feet 3 inches in diameter. The two hatches, accessible by means of conning towers, located in the forward and aft of the vessel, are estimated to have originally measured 16.5 inches in width and 21 inches in length.
- The small sizing of the hatches and the cramped quarters made entering, exiting and maneuvering about the ship remarkably difficult.
- Hunley was designed for a crew of eight, seven to turn the hand-cranked ducted propeller at about 3.5 horse-power and one officer to steer and direct the boat. At the height of its speed, the Hunley could reach 4 knots.


THE HUNLEY

The CSS H. L. Hunley

- On 29 August 1863, Hunley's new crew was preparing to make a test dive when Lt. Payne accidently stepped on the lever controlling the sub's dive planes as she was running on the surface. This caused the Hunley to dive with one of her hatches still open. Payne and two others escaped, but the other five crewmen drowned.
- The vessel was recovered and on 15 October 1863, Hunley failed to surface after a mock attack, killing all eight crewmen, including its inventor, Horace L. Hunley, who had joined the crew for the exercise.
- The Confederate Navy once more salvaged the submarine and returned her to service.

The CSS H. L. Hunley – Spar Torpedo

- A spar torpedo – a copper cylinder containing 135 pounds of black powder - was attached to a 22-foot long wooden spar mounted on Hunley’s bow.
- The spar torpedo would be jammed in the target’s side by ramming and then detonated by a mechanical trigger attached to
- The submarine by a line so that as she backed away from her target, the torpedo would then explode.

The CSS H. L. Hunley – Spar Torpedo

- After Horace Hunley’s death, General Beauregard, the officer in charge of the Hunley’s operations, ordered that the submarine should no longer be used to attack underwater. An iron pipe was then attached to her bow, angled downwards so the explosive charge would be delivered sufficiently underwater to make it effective.

Attacking the USS Housatonic

- **Hunley made her only attack against an enemy target on the night of 17 February 1864. The target was the U. S. Navy ship, USS Housatonic, a 1,260 ton wooden-hulled steam-powered screw sloop-of-war with 12 large cannons, which was stationed at the entrance to Charleston, about 5 miles offshore.**

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- **Officered by Lt. George E. Dixon with a crew of seven and hoping to break the naval blockade of the city, the Hunley successfully attacked Housatonic, ramming Hunley's only spar torpedo against the enemy's hull, just outboard from the ship's powder supply room.**

Attacking the USS Housatonic

- The torpedo was detonated, sending the Housatonic to the bottom of the harbor in three minutes, along with five of her crewmen. Hunley and her crew went missing after the attack. They would not be found for over 100 years.
- Two blue lights were the pre-arranged signal that the Hunley had delivered the spar torpedo and the plan was for bonfires to be lit on the shore to guide the sub back to port. A look-out on Housatonic reported that he saw a blue light on the water after his ship sank.

The CSS H. L. Hunley

- The sunken sub was located in 1995 and after extensive surveys of its condition and the requisite planning, the sub was brought to the surface on 8 August 2000. No damage was found when she was brought to the surface and taken to the Warren Lasch Conservation Center at the former Charleston Navy Yard and placed in a specially designed tank of fresh water to await conservation.

The CSS H. L. Hunley

The CSS H. L. Hunley

- Upon removal of the silt inside the hull, the skeletons of the crew members were found seated at their stations, with no signs of skeletal trauma.
- Subsequent investigations revealed that the sub may have been less than 16 feet from the Housatonic when the torpedo exploded. The short distance between the torpedo and the vessel, in addition to the signs that the crew had died instantaneously and without a struggle to survive, led a team of blast trauma specialists from Duke University to theorize that the Hunley's crew was killed by the blast itself, which could have trans-mitted pressure waves inside the vessel without damaging its hull.
- The crew was likely killed by the explosion of their own torpedo, which could have caused immediate pulmonary blast trauma.

The CSS H. L. Hunley – Lt. George E. Dixon

- **Back story of Lt. George E. Dixon**

Original photo, age unknown

Forensic facial reconstruction

The CSS H. L. Hunley – Lt. George E. Dixon

- In 2002, when lead researcher Maria Jacobsen, examining the area close to the remains of the sub’s Officer, (later identified as Lt. George E. Dixon), found a misshapen $20 gold piece, minted in 1860, with the inscription “Shiloh April 6, 1862, My Life Preserver G.E.D.” on a sanded-smooth area of the coin’s reverse side, and a forensic anthropologist found a healed injury to Lt. Dixon’s hip bone.

The CSS H. L. Hunley – Lt. George E. Dixon

- **Traces of lead were also found on the dented coin. The findings matched a family legend that Dixon's Sweetheart had given him the coin to protect him. Dixon had the coin with him in his trouser's watch pocket at the Battle of Shiloh, where he was wounded in the thigh on 6 April 1862.**
- **The bullet struck the coin in his pocket, saving his leg and possibly his life. He had the gold coin engraved and carried it with him as a lucky charm.**
- **Apart from the submarine commander, Lt. George E. Dixon, the identities of the volunteer crewmen of the Hunley had long remained a mystery.**

The CSS H. L. Hunley – Lt. George E. Dixon

- A physical anthropologist at the Smithsonian's National Museum of Natural History, examined the remains and determined that 4 of the men were American born while the other 4 were of European birth based on the chemical signatures left on the men's teeth and bones by the predominant components of their diet – mostly corn for the 4 Americans, and mostly wheat and rye for 4 of European birth.
- By examining Civil War records, and conducting extensive DNA testing with possible relatives here and in Europe, all seven crew members were ID'd in early 2004. On 17 April 2004, the remains of the crew were laid to rest with full Confederate Military honors at Magnolia Cemetery in Charleston, even though only two of the crew were from Confederate States.

Section 5

Back to Wilmer Mclean

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- In the early spring of 1865, it was becoming apparent that the South had, for all intents and purposes, lost the war, and the talk of a southern surrender was turning into a reality.
- When in early April Lee sent word to General Grant that he would, in fact, sign surrender documents, Grant directed his aides to find a suitable location for the surrender signing.
- After a brief search, the site of a beautiful brick home was decided upon. And who was the owner of this beautiful brick home? None other than Wilmer McLean, who had fled Manassas VA five years earlier to escape the ravages of that first major battle of the war.

Back to Wilmer Mclean

- **Thus the front parlor Wilmer's beautiful home became the site of Confederate General Robert E. Lee's surrender of the southern armies to Union General Ulysses Grant on April 9th, 1865, leading Wilmer McLean to say that "The War began in my front yard and ended in my front parlor".**
- **Thus ends the Civil War, that saw 620,000 casualties, or one out of every four men and boys who served during the war.**

The Gettysburg Address

Four score and seven years ago our fathers brought forth on this continent, a new nation, conceived in Liberty, and dedicated to the proposition that all men are created equal.

Now we are engaged in a great civil war, testing whether that nation, or any nation so conceived and so dedicated, can long endure. We are met on a great battle-field of that war. We have come to dedicate a portion of that field, as a final resting place for those who here gave their lives that that nation might live. It is altogether fitting and proper that we should do this.

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The Gettysburg Address

But, in a larger sense, we can not dedicate -- we can not consecrate -- we can not hallow -- this ground. The brave men, living and dead, who struggled here, have consecrated it, far above our poor power to add or detract. The world will little note, nor long remember what we say here, but it can never forget what they did here. It is for us the living, rather, to be dedicated here to the unfinished work which they who fought here have thus far so nobly advanced. It is rather for us to be here dedicated to the great task remaining before us -- that from these honored dead we take increased devotion to that cause for which they gave the last full measure of devotion -- that we here highly resolve that these dead shall not have died in vain -- that this nation, under God, shall have a new birth of freedom -- and that government of the people, by the people, for the people, shall not perish from the earth.

Abraham Lincoln
November 19, 1863